

ZOKARIO EDITIONS

The Last Lighthouse

*A novel about a keeper, an island, and the
ships we refuse to stop waiting for.*

DIGITAL EDITION · 2026



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The Keeper

The lamp had been officially dark for eleven years, which was, Maren felt, exactly the kind of thing officials would believe. Every evening at civil dusk she climbed the hundred and four steps with the oilcan she no longer needed and the matches she did, and by full dark the tower of Brenholm was throwing its old gold rope across the water, hand over hand, out toward the shipping lanes that had moved forty miles south the summer her brother's boat did not come home.

The islanders had called her mad, back when there were islanders. Now there was only the ferry twice a month, the shop that opened when Agnes felt like it, and the grey house at the harbour where Maren mended nets for mainland fishermen who paid in envelopes and never came upstairs to ask about the light. Which was fine. Which was, in fact, the arrangement she had built her whole life around: a question no one asked, burning at the top of a tower every night, visible for nineteen miles.

She was sixty-one years old. She had been keeping a decommissioned light for eleven years, and a promise for thirty-two. On the night the storm brought her the stranger, she had just replaced the second mantle and was thinking, as she thought most nights at exactly this

altitude, that the sea gives back everything except what you actually asked for.

The wave that put Tomas Vik on the shingle of Brenholm was, by the harbourmaster's later estimate, the seventh of a set that had no business this far east. Maren saw none of it. She saw only, in the second sweep of her illegal light, a shape on the beach that had not been there in the first.

What the Sea Returns

He was alive, which complicated things. The dead she knew how to receive; the island had taught her the full liturgy of that. But the man on the shingle was breathing in long ragged pulls, one hand closed so tightly around a scratched orange case that she had to prise his fingers back one by one, apologising to each of them, before she could get him onto the sledge.

The case she put on the kitchen table while he slept in her brother's bed, in her brother's unworn thirty-two-year-old sweater, because some economies of grief are simply practical. She did not open it. It had a latch and a rubber seal and the particular self-importance of something meant to survive what its owner might not, and she sat across from it most of the night, drinking tea gone cold, aware that she was afraid of a plastic box and unable to laugh herself out of it.

At four in the morning the stranger spoke from the doorway, in an accent she couldn't place and a voice like dragged shingle. 'You're her,' he said. 'The keeper. The one who kept it burning.' He nodded at the case as though it had introduced them. 'Then that belongs to you. I've been trying to deliver it for nine years.'

PART TWO

The Letter

The letter inside was dated the third of April, thirty-two years ago: four days after the Signe went down with all hands, three days after the sea had officially stopped looking, and one day before Maren had lit the lamp for the first time against every regulation in the book.

It was in her brother's handwriting. It was addressed to her. And it began with the seven words that would take the rest of the novel, and the rest of her, to answer: 'If you are reading this, keep going...'

PART THREE

The Crossing

To finish what the letter started, Maren must do the one thing thirty-two years of keeping faith never required of her: leave the island, cross the water her brother did not, and knock on a door in a city that believes she died with the rest of Brenholm.

Tomas offers to take her. His reasons, like his boat, are borrowed and patched, and the crossing will demand the truth about both.



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